The look on my parents' faces at Heathrow when I got back to England, that picture of an effigy of me hanging outside a pub, the snarls from the crowd at Upton Park, and all the rest of it: gone. The film that had been running in my head for so long just stopped dead. Burnt away. Out of my mind for the first time in four years.

Arms outstretched, I sprinted across the grass towards our supporters with a team of England players in red shirts doing their best to get to me before I could disappear into the crowd. I couldn't have wished the burden away. I had to live through it. What had happened in 1998 had done a lot to make me the person I'd become, captaining my country at another World Cup in 2002. But with one kick, it was all off my shoulders for good. Right at that moment I was sure that if I leapt up I'd be able to fly. Suddenly, the other lads were in the air and down on my back. Sol first, then Trevor Sinclair. Rio was there, holding me so tight I could barely catch my breath. This wasn't just my moment. It was a moment for all of us. And then, just as suddenly, came the reminder that we weren't done here. Argentina were going to kick off. A minute later we were going to hear the whistle, but only for half-time, not for the end of the game.

In the dressing room, there was no shouting, no screaming. It was quiet, charged; as if the room wasn't big enough to cram in the energy of the players inside it. *Wouldn't it be great if my goal was the winner?* We went out and, in the second half, picked up where we'd left off in the first. No standing back this time, like we had against Sweden. No giving away possession; not early on anyway. We went looking for another goal. The England defense was a brick wall. Further forward, we were picking off Argentina's passes and then playing around them. Teddy Sheringham came on for Emile Heskey and almost scored. If the Argentine keeper Cavallero hadn't punched away Teddy's volley from the edge of the box, after we'd passed it from one end of the field to the other, it would have been one of the greatest-ever England goals.

Nicky Butt was the best player on the field. It was fantastic to see him prove himself on this stage. He wasn't even guaranteed a start in midfield at United, never mind for England, but he got his chance here because Steven Gerrard missed the tournament through injury. Nicky's a quiet lad, with a really dry sense of humor. He'd never be a character to say: look at me, look at what I can do. But here he was, against what many were saying was the best team in the world, running the game. Other people saw for the first time in Japan what we'd known at United all along.